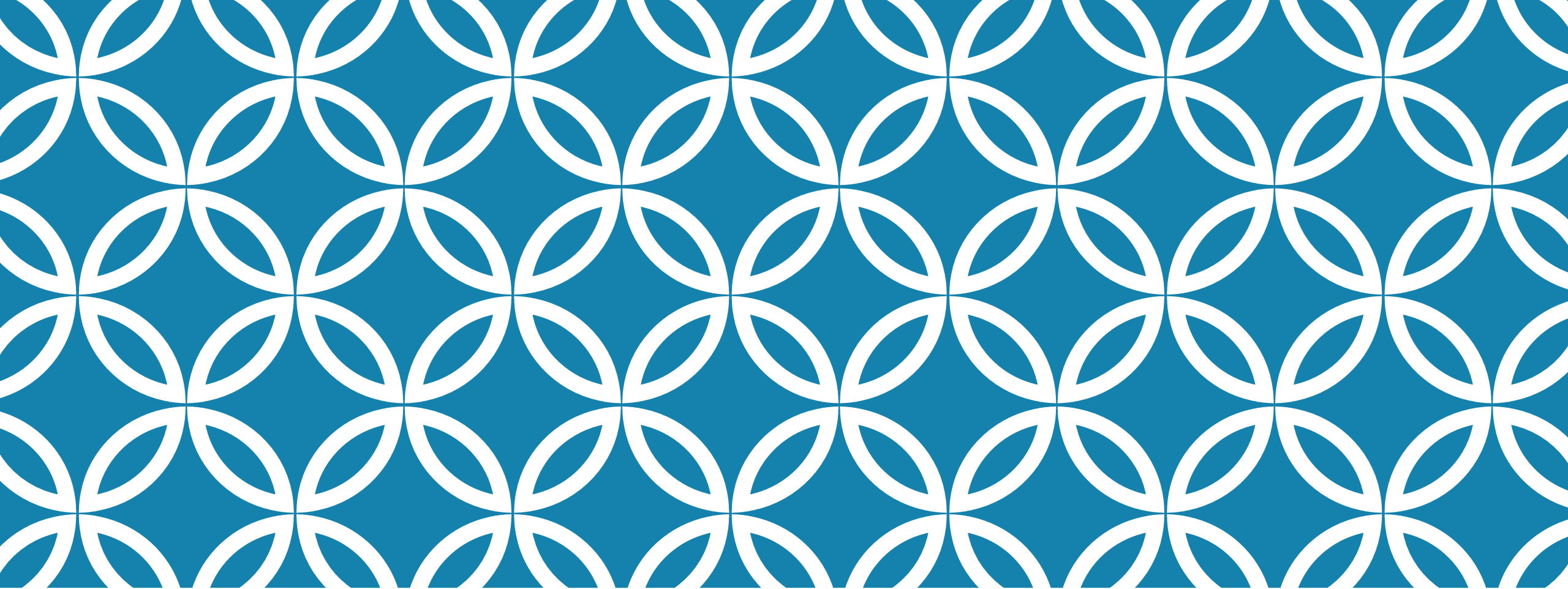
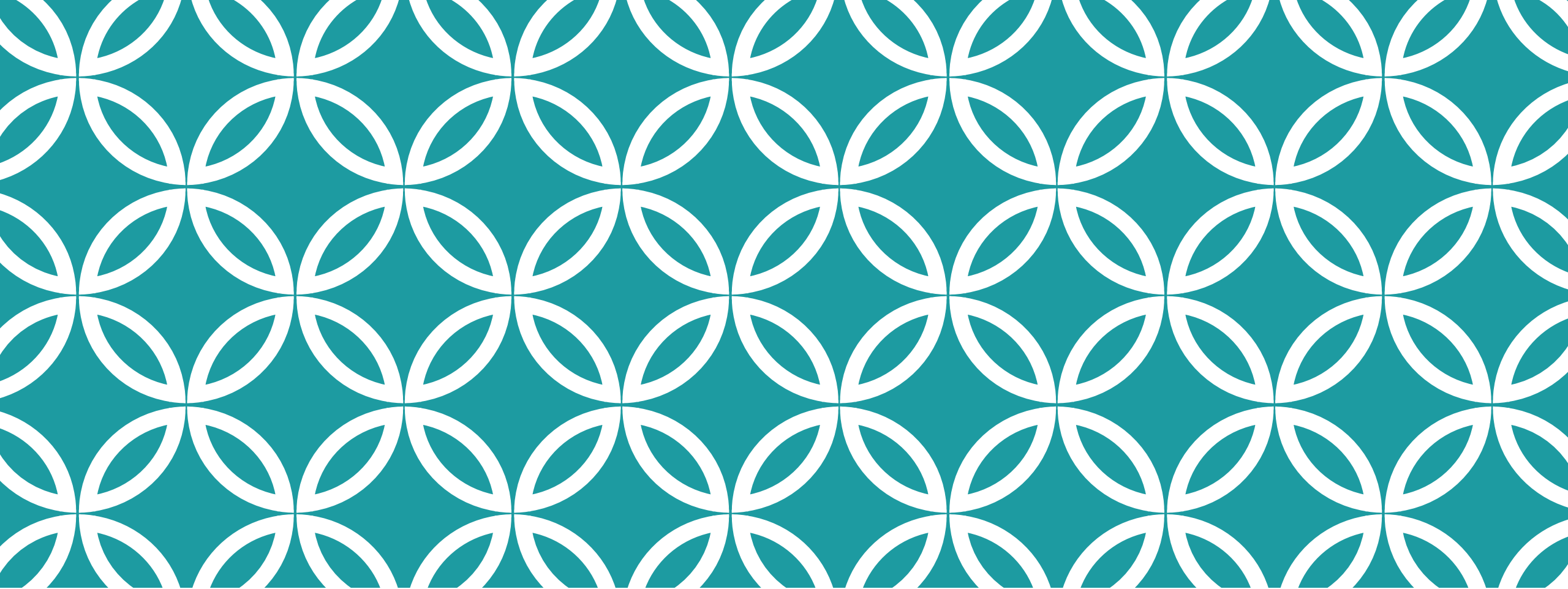




PUBP309: EDUCATION POLICY

Higher education Systemic Issues

Shivakumar Jolad
FLAME University



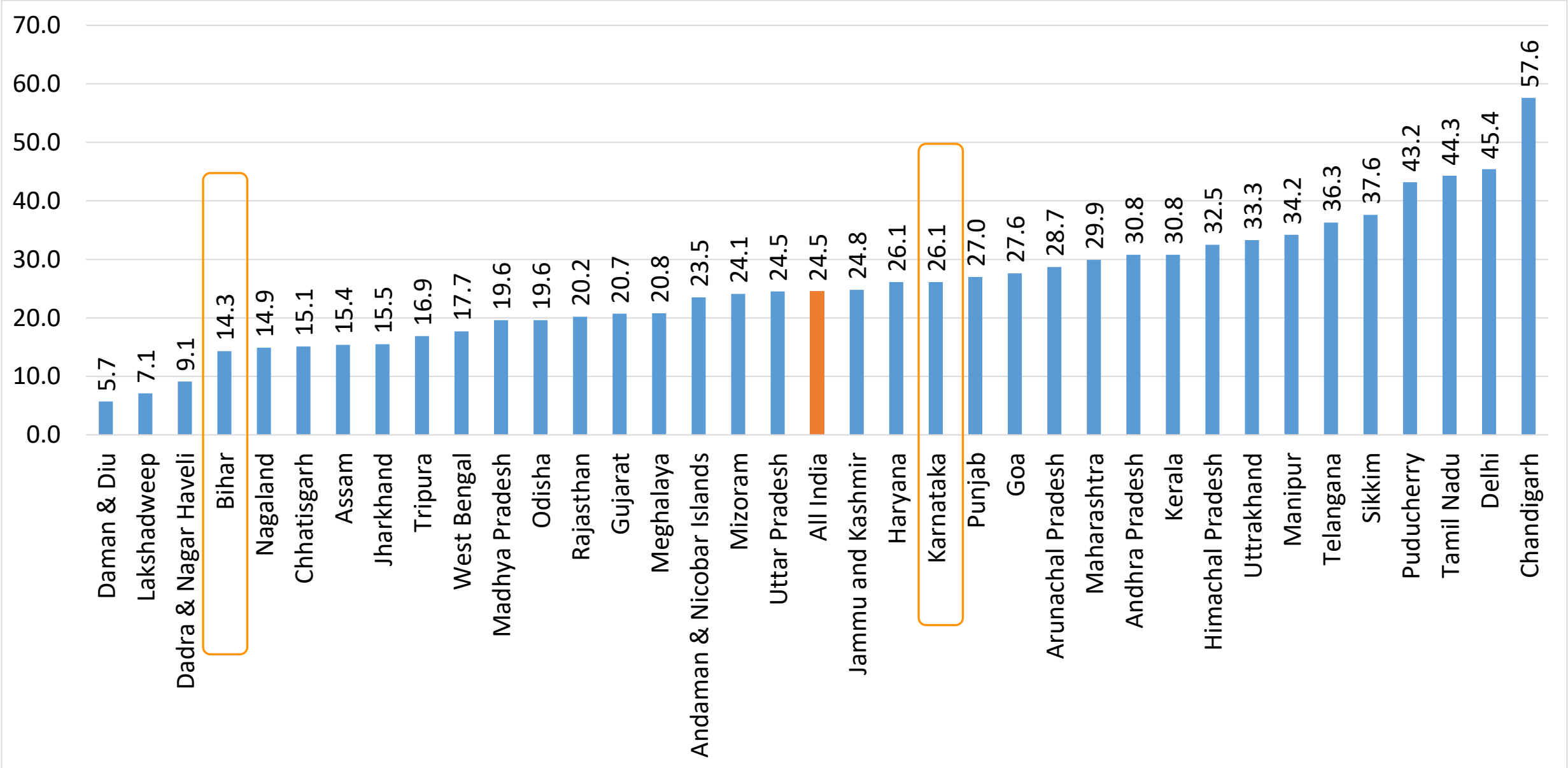
SYSTEMIC ISSUES IN HIGHER EDUCATION



18-23 YEARS: EDUCATION AND LABOR FORCE

- For a long time in India, the 18-23 age group meant entry into the labour force.
- **As recently as 2001, only one out of 10 in this age group received any college education.**
- India's Gross Enrolment Rate (GER) in higher education more than doubled from mere 11% in 2001 to 25% in 2015.
- There are currently around ~~799~~—(993) universities, ~~39,071~~—(39,931) colleges, and 11,923 stand-alone institutions (not affiliated with universities) (AISHE, 2015-16).
- Among the large states, **Delhi has the highest GER of 45.4%, and Bihar has the lowest GER of 14.3%**

GROSS ENROLLMENT RATIO IN HIGHER ED- ACROSS STATES



UNIVERSITIES AND COLLEGES IN INDIA TODAY

Type of university	Number of Universities
Central University	46
Central Open University	1
Institution of National Importance	127
State Public University	371
Institution Under State Legislature Act	5
State Open University	14
State Private University	304
State Private Open University	1
Deemed University- Government	34
Deemed University- Government Aided	10
Deemed University- Private	80
Grand Total	993

298 affiliating Universities and they have **39,931** colleges.

There are 13 Universities, which have 500 or more colleges.

Close to 1000 Universities

CHALLENGES IN HIGHER ED

Fragmentation of the higher education system: India has over 800 universities and approximately 40,000 colleges, reflecting the overall severe fragmentation and small size of HEIs currently in the country. Remarkably, over 40% of all colleges in the country run only a single programme, far from the multidisciplinary style of higher education that will be required in the 21st century. In fact, over 20% of colleges have enrolment below 100, while only 4% of colleges have enrolment over 3000 (AISHE 2016-17). To make matters worse, thousands of the smaller colleges hardly have any teaching faculty at all, and there is little or no education taking place - thus affecting severely the integrity of the higher education system in the country.

This fragmentation of the system leads directly to severe suboptimality on various fronts: resource utilisation, the range and number of programmes and disciplines, the range and number of faculty, and the ability to carry out high-quality multidisciplinary research.

Too many silos; too much early specialisation and streaming of students into disciplines: India's higher education has developed rigid boundaries of disciplines and fields, along with a narrow view of what constitutes

education. As already mentioned, its most harmful expression is in the enormous number of mono-field institutions that have been developed, most notably in the professional and vocational fields. For example, there are thousands of stand alone teacher education institutions, and most engineering and medical colleges are also stand alone institutions. Even in institutions that offer programmes across more than one discipline, there are silos that separate disciplines within these institutions, e.g. students in engineering are generally not encouraged or even allowed to take courses outside of their single programmes (e.g. in the arts, humanities, social sciences, or even in the pure sciences), thereby producing thousands of students with identical educations rather than true individuals and humans exercising their own creativity, and developing their own talents and interests. Such rigid boundaries and silos violate the basic requirement of good higher education.

YASHPAL COMMITTEE FOR REJUVENATION OF HIGHER EDUCATION- 2009

“A university is a ... unique space, which covers the entire universe of knowledge”, and recommended that **“All universities must be teaching cum research universities,** and all research bodies must connect with universities in their vicinity and create teaching opportunities for their researchers.”

Universities should have undergraduate programmes, ending the isolation of disciplines in Science, Engineering, Management and humanities.

National Commission for Higher Education and Research (NCHER) under which the various functions of the existing regulatory agencies would be subsumed.



Prof. Yash Pal

All higher education will happen in multidisciplinary institutions with teaching programmes across disciplines and fields to ensure optimised resources, integration across disciplines and vibrant, large education communities.

Imaginative and flexible curricular structures will enable creative combinations of disciplines for students to study, and would offer multiple useful entry and exit points, thus demolishing currently prevalent rigid boundaries and creating new possibilities for lifelong learning. Graduate (masters and doctoral) level education in large multidisciplinary universities, while providing rigorous research-based specialisation, would also provide opportunities for multidisciplinary work, including in education and in industry.

P9.2. Moving towards a more liberal undergraduate education: This goes hand-in-hand with the first policy initiative. The needs of the 21st century require that liberal broad-based multidisciplinary education become the basis for all higher education. This will help develop well-rounded individuals that

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National Education Policy 2019

ACCESS

Lack of access, especially in socio-economically disadvantaged areas: Access in higher education has significantly improved in the past few decades, but is still not sufficient to reach all our young citizens; equity in and quality of education still remain a big challenge. While the GER of higher education has risen over the last several years, to around 25%, and notable progress has been made, this Policy aims for GER to reach 50% by 2035, in order to fulfil the aspirations of our youth and to form the basis for a vibrant society and economy. This implies more than doubling enrolment, from the present base of 35 million students, and including increased opportunities and access for students from socio-economically disadvantaged backgrounds and areas.

LACK OF RESEARCH

The lack of research at most universities and colleges, and the lack of transparent and competitive peer reviewed research funding across disciplines: The separation in higher education between teaching institutions and research institutions post-independence has caused much harm, as most universities and colleges in the country today conduct very little research. This is problematic on two fronts. First, so many members of the academic community of the country not conducting (and not incentivised to conduct) scholarly research is an enormous lost opportunity for research and innovation in the country. Secondly, on the education side, it is difficult to have outstanding higher education and teaching in an environment where knowledge creation is not taking place; indeed, how can students be taught to innovate in a location where innovation is not on the agenda?

At the current time, there is no mechanism to seed or mentor research at universities and colleges where research is in a nascent stage particularly at State Universities where 93% of all students in higher education are enrolled. In addition, very little funding is available for novel research ideas and proposals at most HEIs, especially for research in important multidisciplinary and cross-disciplinary areas (e.g. relating to clean water, renewable energy, education and pedagogy, health, etc.).

SUBOPTIMAL GOVERNANCE AND LEADERSHIP OF HIGHER EDUCATION INSTITUTIONS:

Suboptimal governance and leadership of higher education institutions: Governance and leadership of HEIs are, at the current time, deeply influenced and controlled by external bodies and individuals. Often these external influences have vested political and/or commercial interests in the HEIs. Public institutions are often operated as extensions of government departments. There is significant external interference in the selection and functioning of leaders of public institutions; this is all too often starkly visible in undeserving and inappropriate people as leaders of HEIs, appointed through corrupt or arbitrary practices that are not merit based. The educational aspects, including curricula, of HEIs are controlled by multiple external bodies. HEIs are not empowered to manage their own teams, and often have little or no influence on compensation, progression of faculty, and appointments. Internal governance structures have thereby become dysfunctional.

FACULTY AND INSTITUTIONAL AUTONOMY

Moving towards faculty and institutional autonomy: Through faculty autonomy, faculty will be enabled and motivated to innovate in their teaching and pedagogical approaches, student assessment, community service initiatives, and research, and share best practices and ideas with each other in university wide and larger forums in order to continually improve. Through institutional academic and administrative autonomy, institutions will be enabled to start and run novel and cutting-edge programmes, develop innovative curricula, govern more locally given local knowledge of circumstances and requirements, and set up optimal people and career management systems. All of these issues of administration and academics would be best handled (and innovated and improved upon) locally by those who are directly involved in the local issues (namely, faculty and institutional leaders), and they must in due course be empowered to do so.

Substantial and adequate public funding, with stability, must therefore be provided to public institutions to enable such academic and administrative autonomy. Over time, as financial probity and responsibility is demonstrated

Private higher educational institutions will arrange their own funding; however, so long as they publicly disclose their full academic, administrative, and financial details to demonstrate financial probity, and academic and administrative responsibility, they too will move towards full autonomy in order to allow them to strive for excellence.

P9.7. Higher education institutions will be governed by Independent Boards, with complete academic and administrative autonomy: Clear merit based procedures for appointments of the Board of Governors (BoG), the Chancellor, and the Vice Chancellor/Director/Chief Executive of HEI will ensure elimination of external interference, including from the government, and will aim to engage high capacity individuals who are invested in and have strong commitment towards the institution. Accountability for educational outcomes will flow concomitantly to the Board of the institution. Mechanisms will be established to align all stakeholders, including the government (and its bodies), for the long term development of the institution.

P9.8. “Light but tight” regulation: The regulatory system will be transformed to have only one regulator for all higher education, including professional education. Accreditation on basic parameters (such as financial probity) will form the basis for all regulation - these parameters will be minimalistic but rigorously enforced, including shutting down HEIs which do not adhere. Public disclosure of all relevant information by HEIs will be enforced and used for public scrutiny and informed decision making.

The various distinct functions of funding, standard setting, accreditation, and regulation will be separated and will be conducted by independent bodies, eliminating concentration of power and conflicts of interest. Private and public institutions will be treated on par by the regulatory regime. Commercialisation of education will be stopped and philanthropic efforts will be highly encouraged.

RESTRUCTURING OF HIGHER ED

college. All HEIs will aim to become large and multidisciplinary, in order to fulfil the attributes of broad-based education, research, and service required of them. Accordingly, a university will mean a multidisciplinary institution of higher learning that offers undergraduate and graduate programmes, with high quality teaching, research, and service. The definition of universities will thus allow those that place equal emphasis on teaching and research ('research universities') as well as those that place greater emphasis on teaching but still conduct significant research ('teaching universities').

A suitable number of Type 1-3 institutions must be developed in order to ensure geographical diversity with full access, equity, and inclusion. The GER goal that is being set over the period of this Policy is 50%, commensurate with the aspirations of the people and comparable with other rapidly developing nations

NEP calls for a drastic restructuring of higher education- **moving away from the British model of higher education** (3-year undergraduate and 4–5 professional colleges fragmented along with areas and levels) which we followed since 1857.

Draft
**National
Education Policy 2019**

- -
- c. All HEIs will gradually move towards full autonomy - academic, administrative, and eventually financial - in order to enable this vibrant culture. The autonomy of public institutions will be backed by adequate public financial support and stability. Private institutions with public spirited commitment to high quality, equitable education will be encouraged and treated on par. The new regulatory system envisioned by this Policy will foster this overall culture of empowerment and autonomy to innovate, including by gradually phasing out the system of 'affiliated colleges' in order to enable and encourage local innovation.
 - d. The overall higher education sector will be integrated into one higher education system - including professional and vocational education. This Policy, its approach, and specific policy points will be equally applicable to all HEIs across all current streams which would eventually merge into one coherent ecosystem of higher education.

a. **Type 1: Research universities.** These will focus equally on research and teaching: they will dedicate themselves to cutting-edge research for new knowledge creation while at the same time offering the highest quality teaching across undergraduate, masters, Ph.D., professional, and vocational programmes. Many graduate and research institutions do not currently offer undergraduate education, which is essential for ensuring that knowledge from the best institutions gets passed on, on a wide scale, to the next generation. These institutions will be encouraged to introduce undergraduate programmes as well. It is expected that, over a period of two decades, a couple of hundred institutions, say 150–300, will belong to the Type 1 category, and each will aim for on-campus enrolments between 5000 to 25000 or more students. They will aim to become world-class research universities and compete with global institutions.

b. **Type 2: Teaching universities.** These will focus primarily on high quality teaching across disciplines and programmes, including undergraduate, masters and doctoral, professional, vocational, certificate and diploma programmes, while also significantly contributing to cutting-edge research. Such institutions will target enrolments between 5,000 and 25,000 or more on their campuses. It is expected that there will be several hundred such universities, say, between 1000 to 2000, created over a period of two decades. As they begin to achieve higher quality in research and the range of programmes offered, some of them may aim to join the ranks of Type 1 institutions.

c. **Type 3: Colleges.** These will focus almost exclusively on the goal of high quality teaching. These institutions will largely run undergraduate programmes, in addition to diploma and certificate programmes, across disciplines and fields, including vocational and professional. A large number of such autonomous colleges, say 5,000–10,000, will provide high quality liberal undergraduate education, with a target of on-campus enrolments of 2,000–5,000 or higher. These colleges will also be expected to offer certificate,

In the long term (by 2040), the Indian higher education system will consolidate into a far smaller number of institutions, across the three Types of HEIs, but the average size of these institutions will be much larger than the average size today; this will help increase resource efficiency, multidisciplinary capacity and quality, as well as GER.

All types of institutions must be equitably distributed across the states and regions.

Leena Chandran Wadia and Shakila T. Shamsu

Padma M. Sarangapani
Rekha Pappu *Editors-in-Chief*

Handbook of Education Systems in South Asia

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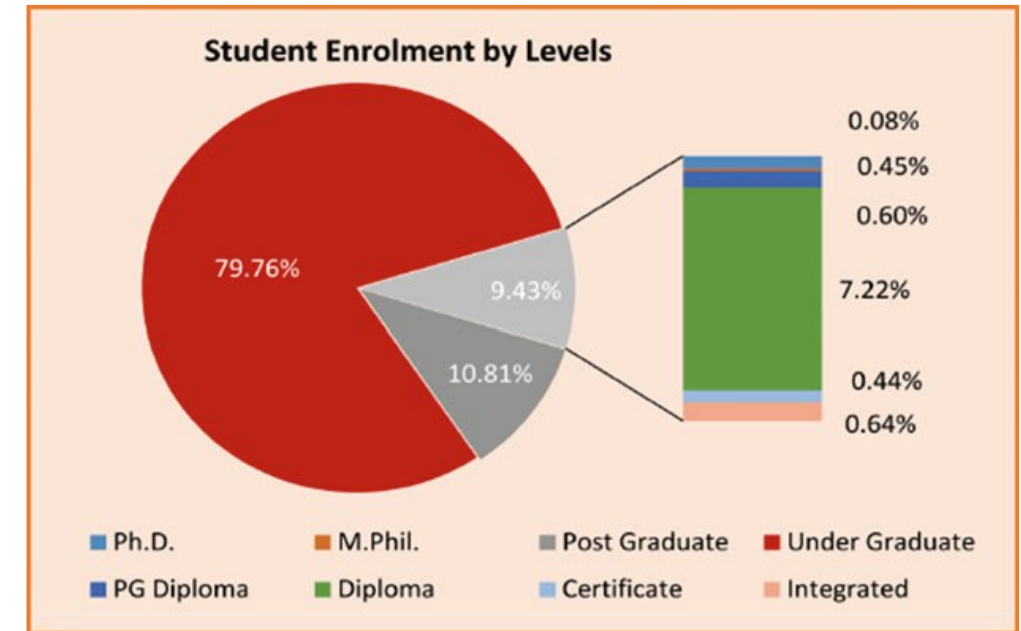
UNDERGRADUATE EDUCATION

Enrollment Patterns and Concentration:

- **UG education dominates** higher education enrolment:
 - ~**80%** of students at UG level (~29.8 million)
 - Additional **7.66%** in diploma and certificate courses
- **Over 63%** of students enrolled in **BA, BSc, and BCom** programs
- Professional courses have **relatively low enrolment**

Employability Concerns:

- Low employability despite high enrolment:
 - **BA: 29.3%, BCom: 30.06%, BSc: 47.37%**
 - **Engineering graduates** more employable (**57.09%**)
- **Curriculum and pedagogy** remain outdated and rigid
 - Limited curricular revision by affiliating universities
 - Overemphasis on **centralized exit exams**



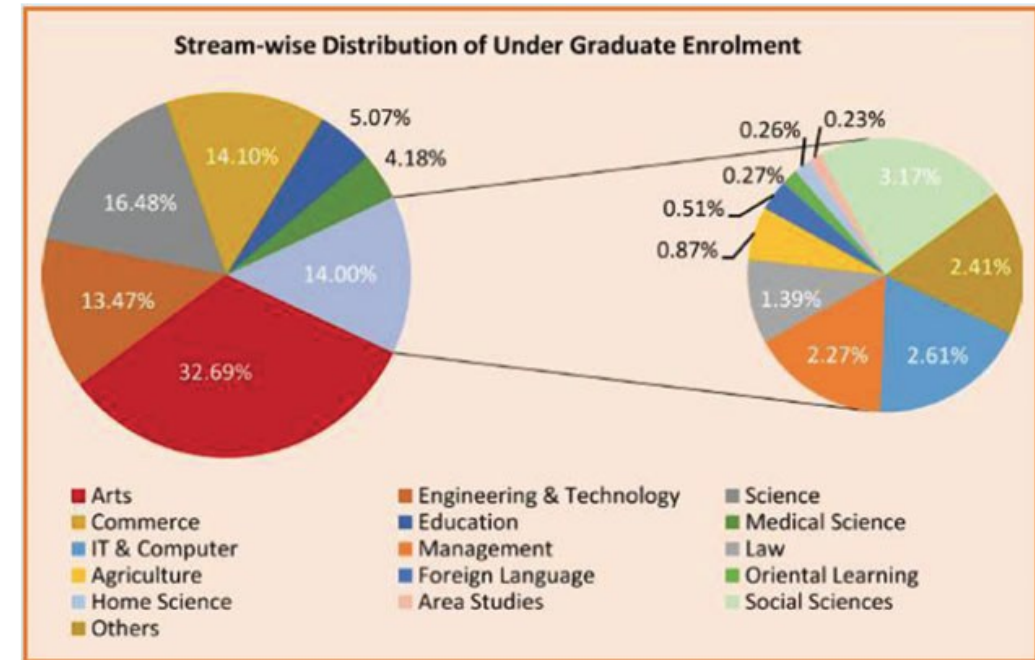
STRUCTURAL FRAGMENTATION AND LACK OF FLEXIBILITY

Pedagogical and Curricular Rigidities:

- Faculty have limited role in **designing curriculum, pedagogy, and assessment**
- **Lack of experiential learning:** no projects, fieldwork, portfolios, or interdisciplinary case studies
- **Fixed subject combinations** limit flexibility (e.g., Chemistry only via PCM)
- Early **disciplinary streaming** restricts liberal/broad-based education

Fragmented Institutional Landscape:

- **64.4% of colleges** enroll <500 students; **16.3%** enroll <100
- Fragmentation hinders **peer learning** and resource utilization
- **34.8% of colleges** offer only one program (e.g., B.Ed. in isolation at 38% of such colleges)
- Most UG colleges are **non-residential**, leading to academic and social isolation



POSTGRADUATE EDUCATION AND RESEARCH

- **Low Enrolment:**

- Only **10.81%** in Master's, **0.45%** in PhD programs (AISHE 2019)
- Just **1.73 lakh** students enrolled in PhD (regular + integrated)

- **Impact on Faculty & Research:**

- Fewer postgraduates → limited **faculty pipeline**
- **Many PG programs lack research component**
- Junior faculty often begin without adequate research exposure

- **Institutional Weaknesses:**

- **Small PG departments**, often 1–2 senior faculty
- **Weak research culture** in state & private universities
- **Separation of teaching and research** prevalent (YPC 2009; Altbach 2012)

- **Low R&D Investment & Output:**

- India: **156 researchers/million**, vs. **1113 (China)**, **4231 (USA)**, **8255 (Israel)**
- Patent filings (2018): **India – 50,055**, **China – 1.54 million**, **USA – 597,141**

ROLE OF THE PRIVATE SECTOR IN HIGHER EDUCATION

Key Trends & Data:

- **77.8% of all colleges** are privately managed
 - Includes **13.5% private-aided** colleges
 - **64.3% private-unaided** colleges account for **45.2% of enrolment**
- **Government colleges = 22.2% of institutions, but cater to 33.6% enrolment**
- **75.5%** of all standalone HEIs (e.g., nursing, teacher training) are pr

Challenges & Concerns:

- Many private HEIs are **covertly for-profit** despite nonprofit mandat
- **High fees**, limited scholarships widen **socio-economic inequality**
- Faculty quality often poor due to **low-cost hiring practices**
- Dominance in **professional education**, but many **struggle with placements**
- Regulatory oversight exists, but **implementation remains weak**

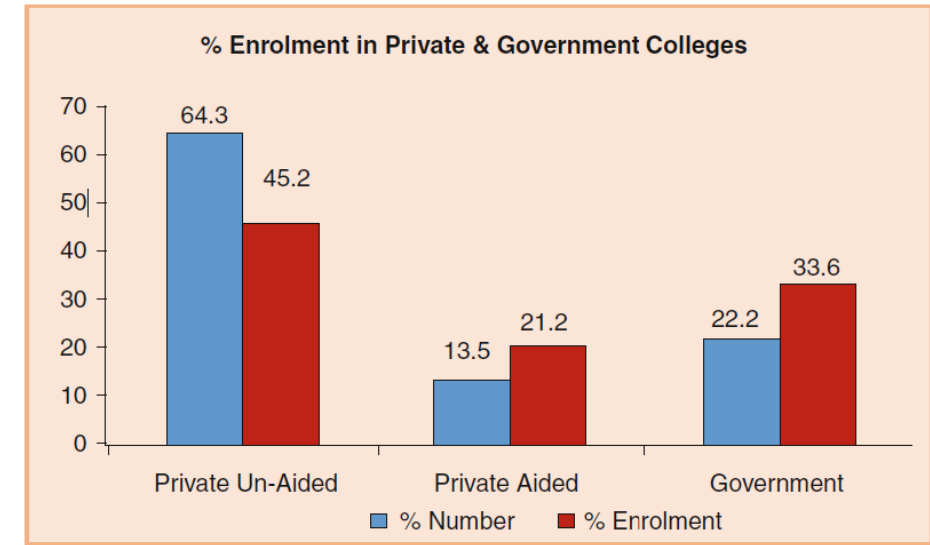


Fig. 5 Percentage numbers and enrolment in private, private-aided, and government colleges (Source: AISHE 2019)

CHALLENGES IN INDIAN HIGHER EDUCATION PROVISIONING

Global Comparison Insights (British Council 2015):

- India shares common **large-system challenges** with China, USA, Russia, Brazil:
 - **Persistent inequalities** in access (by region, gender, socio-economic status)
 - **Curriculum-employability disconnect**
 - **Weak quality assurance systems**
 - Limited **vocational education opportunities**
 - **Governance & regulation** reforms needed
 - Need for **sustainable financing**
 - **Lack of internationalization**

System Fragmentation:

- India: **37.4 million students**, over **50,000 HEIs**
- China: **45 million students**, just **~3,000 universities**
- Results in **dispersed enrolment**, inconsistent quality

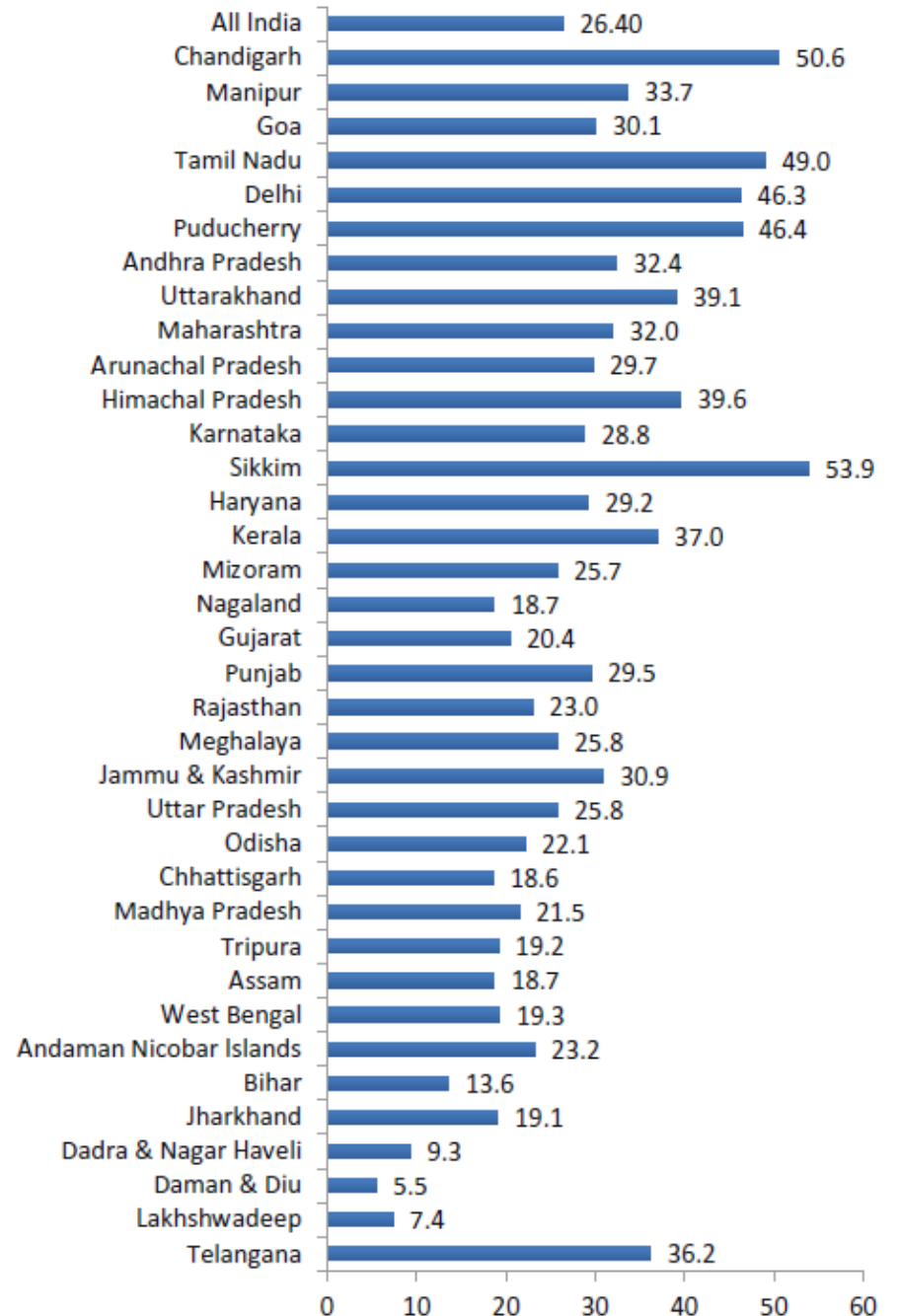
ACCESS AND EQUITY IN HIGHER EDUCATION

Constitutional & Policy Framework:

- **Reservations/Quotas** for SCs, STs, and later OBCs aligned with constitutional values
- **Additional disparities:** region, gender, religion, disability, economic status
- **Intersectionality** compounds disadvantage (e.g., rural + female + SC/S

Geographical Disparities in GER (Gross Enrolment Ratio):

- GER varies widely:
 - High: **Sikkim (53.9), Tamil Nadu (49.0)**
 - Low: **Bihar (13.6), Lakshadweep (7.4), Daman & Diu (5.5)**
- **Southern states** fare better than eastern, central, and northeastern regions
- Access also limited by **socioeconomic and cultural factors** (e.g., migration, hesitancy)



TARGETED INTERVENTIONS AND STRUCTURAL CHALLENGES

- **Gender parity in GER achieved:** Women (26.4%) now slightly ahead of men (26.3%)
- **Muslim students underrepresented**, especially in STEM
- **Language barriers** in STEM for students from regional medium schools
- **Faculty diversity lacking:** Underrepresentation of SC/ST/OBC and Muslims

Ongoing Interventions:

- **Central & state schemes:**
 - HEIs in **aspirational districts**, NE states, J&K, extremism-affected regions
 - Scholarships, interest subsidies, free coaching, bridge courses
 - Schemes for PwD students

Need for Systemic Support:

- First-generation students face **learning gaps from school onward**
- **Remedial & bridge courses in English, Math** crucial at every level

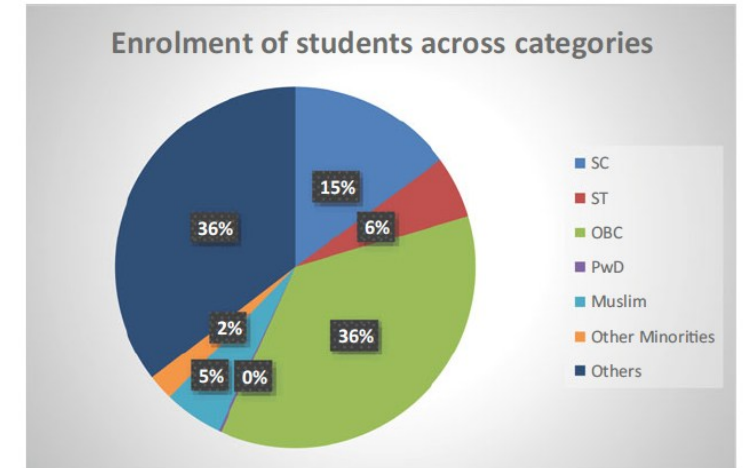


Fig. 7 Distribution of the enrolment of students across categories. (Source: AISHE 2019)

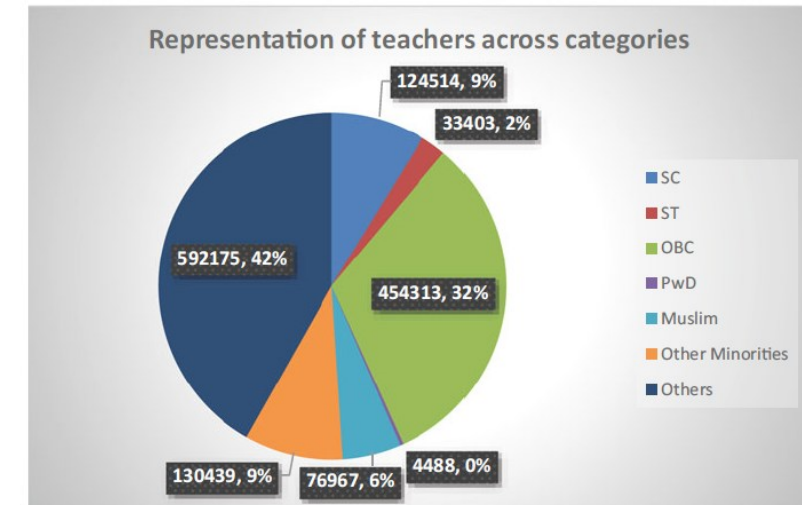


Fig. 8 Distribution of teaching staff by category. (Source: AISHE 2019)

INSTITUTIONAL AUTONOMY & QUALITY CONCERNS IN HIGHER EDUCATION

Key Issues Undermining Quality:

- **Fragmentation of HEIs** reduces peer learning and resource efficiency
- **Rigid affiliation system** promotes rote learning and centralized exit exams
- **Fixed subject combinations** limit curricular flexibility
- **Curriculum disconnected** from societal needs and student experiences

Lack of Autonomy:

- Institutions have **limited financial powers**; major purchases go through govt. bureaucracy
- Faculty treated like **government staff**, subject to **transfers**
- Minimal incentive for faculty to **innovate or build long-term programs/labs**

VOCATIONAL EDUCATION — SCOPE, CHALLENGES, AND OPPORTUNITIES

System Overview:

- Less than **5% of Indian youth (19–24)** receive formal vocational education (vs. 52% USA, 75% Germany, 96% South Korea)
- **Institutions:**
 - 14,987 ITIs (~1.57 million capacity)
 - 3,440 Polytechnics (~1.51 million capacity)

Challenges:

- **Stigma:** Perceived as inferior to academic education
- **Poor planning & infrastructure** limit practical training
- **BVoc programs** underfunded and lack sustainable models

Policy Pushes:

- **UGC BVoc guidelines (2013)** and **NPSDE (2015)** aim to integrate vocational education in **25% of schools/colleges**
- Emphasis on **apprenticeships, internships, workbenches**

HIGHER EDUCATION REFORMS IN INDIA

Historical Context & Key Policies:

- Only **two comprehensive National Education Policies** before 2020:
 - **NPE 1968** (based on Kothari Commission, 1966)
 - **NPE 1986**, modified in 1992
- Reforms largely driven by:
 - **Five-Year Plans (FYPs)**
 - Flagship programs (RUSA, TEQIP, NMTT)
 - National missions (e.g., NMEICT, NKN, NPTEL)

Expansion and Investment (Post-2000):

- Eleventh FYP (2007–12): Major **thrust on “3 Es” – Expansion, Equity, Excellence**
 - Significant increase in funding
 - Setup of **new IITs, IIMs, IIITs, NITs, Central Universities**
 - Infrastructure grants to thousands of affiliated colleges
- Twelfth FYP: **RUSA launched** to strategically fund state HEIs

NEP 2020 AND EMERGING REFORM DIRECTIONS

DNEP 2019 → NEP 2020: Turning Point

- NEP 2020 based on DNEP (Draft NEP 2019)
- Aims for a **complete overhaul** of higher education
- Focuses on **empowering stakeholders**: faculty, HEI leadership, private/public institutions

Major Reform Proposals:

- **Multidisciplinary 4-Year UG Programs**
- **Integration of vocational education** into mainstream
- **Phasing out affiliation system**
- Restructure HEIs into:
 - **Research universities**
 - **Teaching universities**
 - **Autonomous degree-granting college**